Paid With(out) Purpose: Perceptions, Preferences, and the Meaning of Work

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Job Market Presentation

November 7, 2026

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A changing modern work environment

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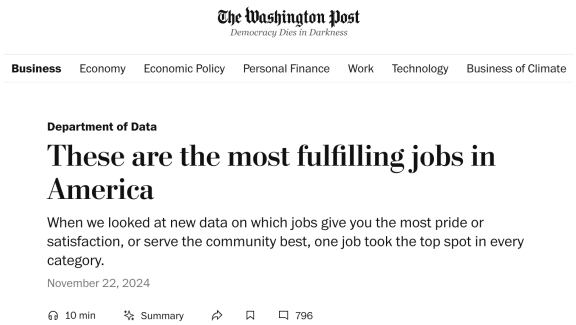
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$\Rightarrow$ Employers may increasingly look to **work meaning** as a nonmonetary way to keep workers engaged, but how best to design and target meaningful work is not yet well understood.

Work meaning appears frequently in popular reporting



The Washington Post
Democracy Dies in Darkness

Business Economy Economic Policy Personal Finance Work Technology Business of Climate

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Finding more meaning in work

Also in this week's newsletter, the US parallels with the 1980s

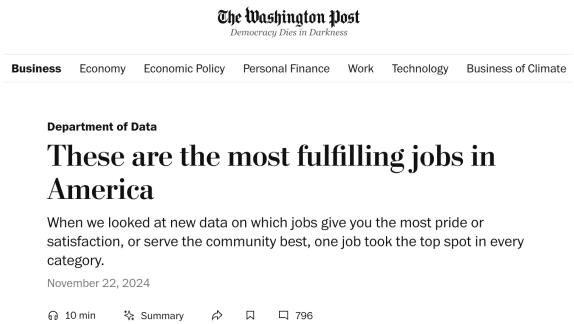


Do you find meaning in your typical workday? Experts urge us to reflect © FT montage/Dreamstime

Bethan Staton

Published MAR 26 2025 1

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"There is this expectation or this desire for people to **find meaning in the work that they're doing** *and feeling like it contributes to some greater good..."* - *Mary Morris-Hyde, Washington Post, 2024*

Two common assumptions about work meaning

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- Do perceptions of meaning identify the workers who would give up pay for meaningful work?
- Do assigning the task more meaningful on average and using each worker's own report of meaning lead to the same conclusions about its effects on output?

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Both tasks share the same constraints, time limits, and images; they differ in their mission statements and in their guidance and examples on how to write a good description

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3. Exploratory: association of perceived meaning with output similar for workers who do and do not value meaning

Contributions

- **Perceptions vs. preferences for work meaning**
  Maestas et al. (2023); De Schouwer and Kesternich (2025); Cassar and Meier (2018); Kesternich et al. (2021); Weber and Milliman (1997); Henkel et al. (2025)
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- **Preferences for meaning and productivity**
  Cnossen and Nikolova (2025); Ashraf et al. (2025); Hendriks and Cnossen (2026); Nikolova and Cnossen (2020)
  ⇒ Trades the external validity of a real workplace for fixed work, worker-and-task-level meaning, and random assignment

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Conceptual framework for work meaning

Worker utility, building on Cassar and Meier (2018):

$$U = \underbrace{Y(w_t, e_t)}_{\text{Monetary benefit}} + \underbrace{M(m_t, e_t)}_{\text{Nonmonetary benefit}} - \underbrace{C(e_t)}_{\text{Effort cost}}$$

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- Weight $\phi \in [0, 1]$ for worker incentive **preferences**: pay-maximizers ($\phi = 1$), meaning-maximizers ($\phi = 0$), mixed incentive-types ($\phi \in (0, 1)$)[2]

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- m_t and ϕ are distinct: a worker's perception need not reveal their preferences

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Observe repeated work choices of AT vs. SD with known pay and meaning[3] $\Rightarrow$ construct incentive types

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Hypothesis 1: A worker's incentive type can be identified through repeated observation of their choice of task, and workers are heterogeneous in their types.

Hypothesis 2: Meaning-maximizers and mixed incentive-types increase their effort on more meaningful tasks, while pay-maximizers do not, since $(1-\phi)\frac{\partial M}{\partial e} = 0$ when $\phi = 1$.

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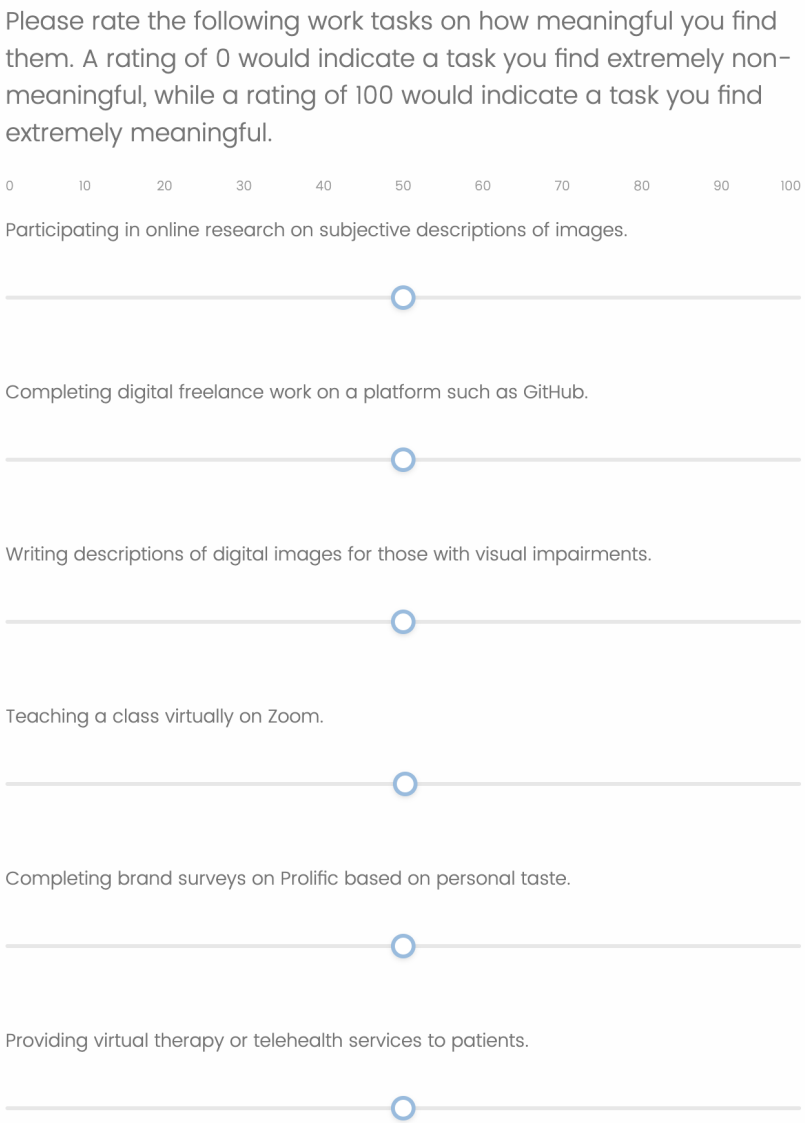
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- Task training Attention check

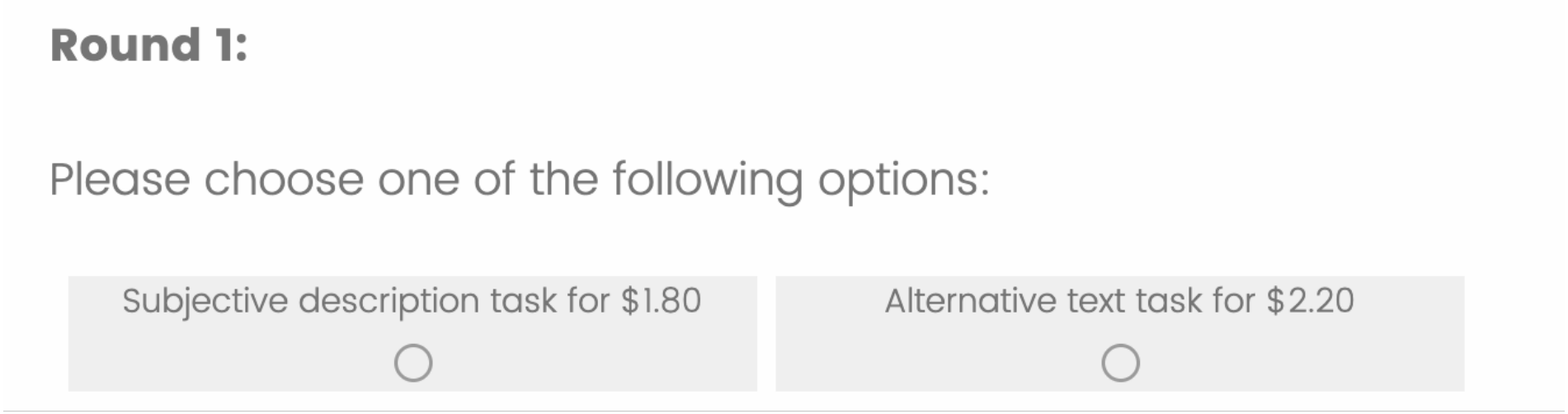
Experimental design: task framings

Subjective Description	Alternative Text
We are conducting research on how subjects describe various images in both human and non-human settings.	We also hope to provide written descriptions alongside images in future experiments to help identify them for participants with visual impairments.
You will have one minute (60 sec) to write a 5-word (minimum) description of the image presented to you.	You will have one minute (60 sec) to write a 5-word (minimum) description of the image presented to you.
Descriptions should be both detailed and accurate, capturing key elements of the image such as setting and main subject.	Descriptions should encompass any notable details or features of the image.
By selecting this option, you consent to your description being used for this research.	By selecting this option, you consent to your description being used for this purpose.

Experimental design: task ratings (randomized order)

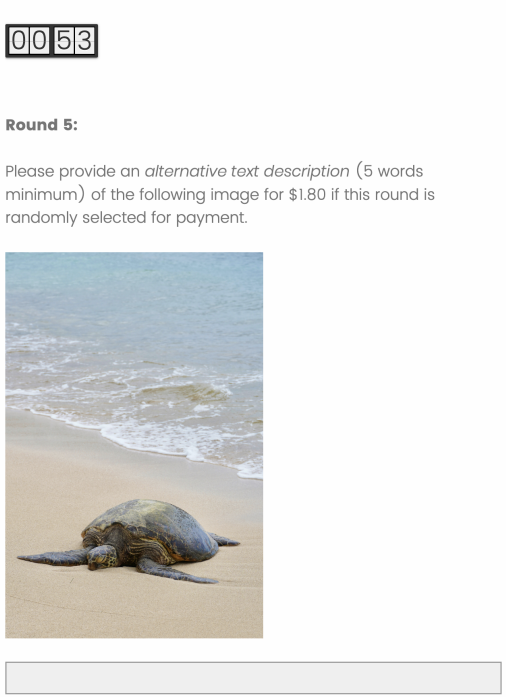


Experimental design: task choice rounds (4×)



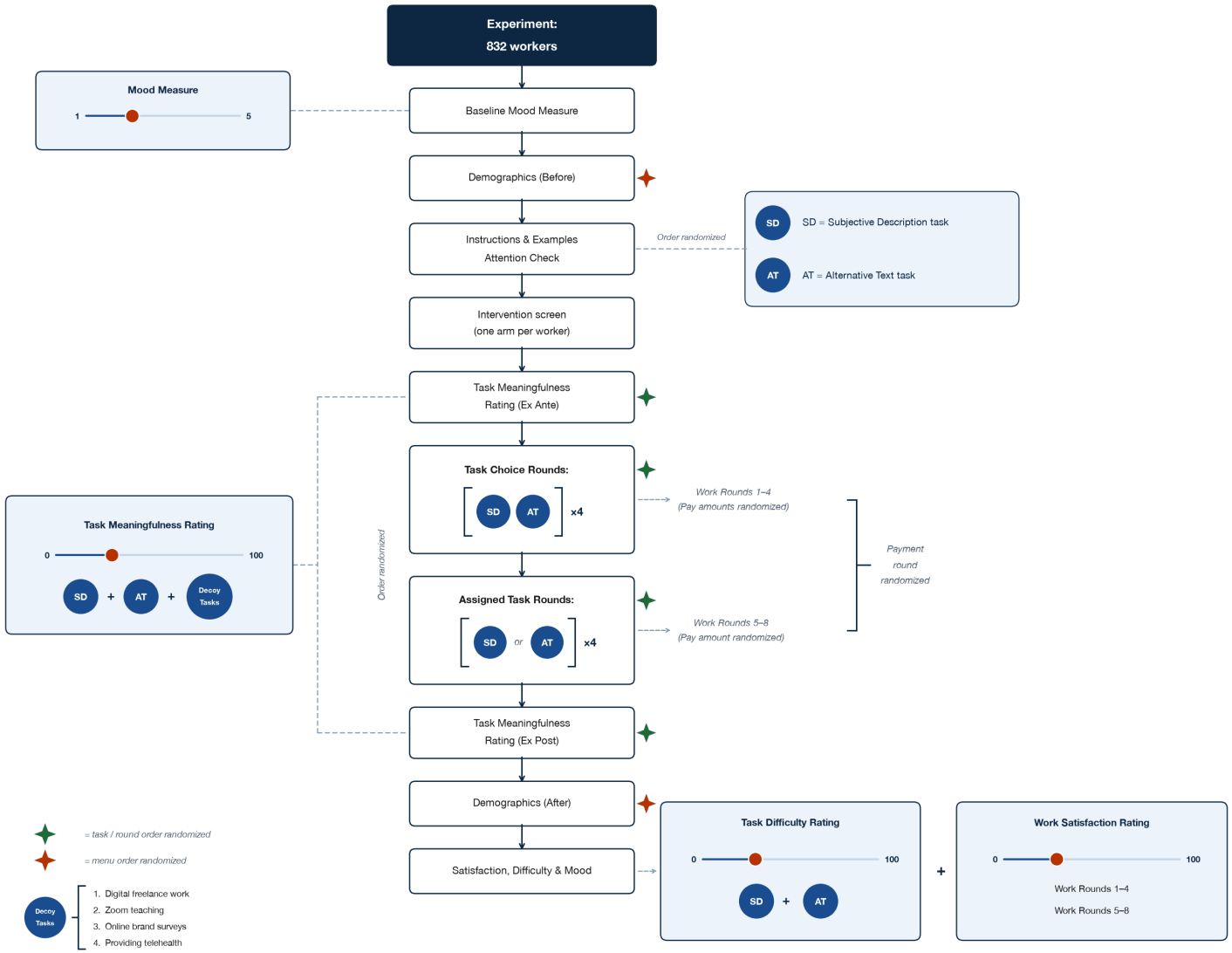
- $w_{SD} \sim U(\$1, \$2)$
- $w_{AT} = \zeta w_{SD}$, $\zeta \sim N(1, 0.01)$: a mean-preserving spread
- Subjects see pay realizations, not distributions
- Subjects then complete their chosen task in 60 seconds

Experimental design: task assignment rounds (4×)



- This subject was randomly assigned the *Alternative Text* task in round 5
- Assignment i.i.d. Bernoulli with equal probability; pay drawn as in choice rounds
- One of 8 rounds randomly selected for payment, plus a base payment of $3–4
- $Y(w_{i\hat{r}}, e_{i\hat{r}}) \equiv w_{i\hat{r}} \cdot \mathbb{I}(e_{i\hat{r}} \geq 5 \text{ words})$: output above 5 words earns nothing more

Experimental design: timeline



Experimental design: outcome variables

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GPT-4o API rating of description quality with image, instructions, and description:

- Separate, independent API calls (temperature 0.2), one run per data collection period; wave fixed effects throughout
- Correlation of quality with wordcount only 0.39
- Treated as a noisy measure of true quality

Examples of well- and poorly-rated descriptions



"A turtle laying on the sand with water from the ocean behind him" (100)

"Sea turtle resting on a sandy beach with waves in the background." (95)

"at the shore sleeping turtle" (45)

"it is a beach" (20)

"Turtle" (10)

"a" (0)

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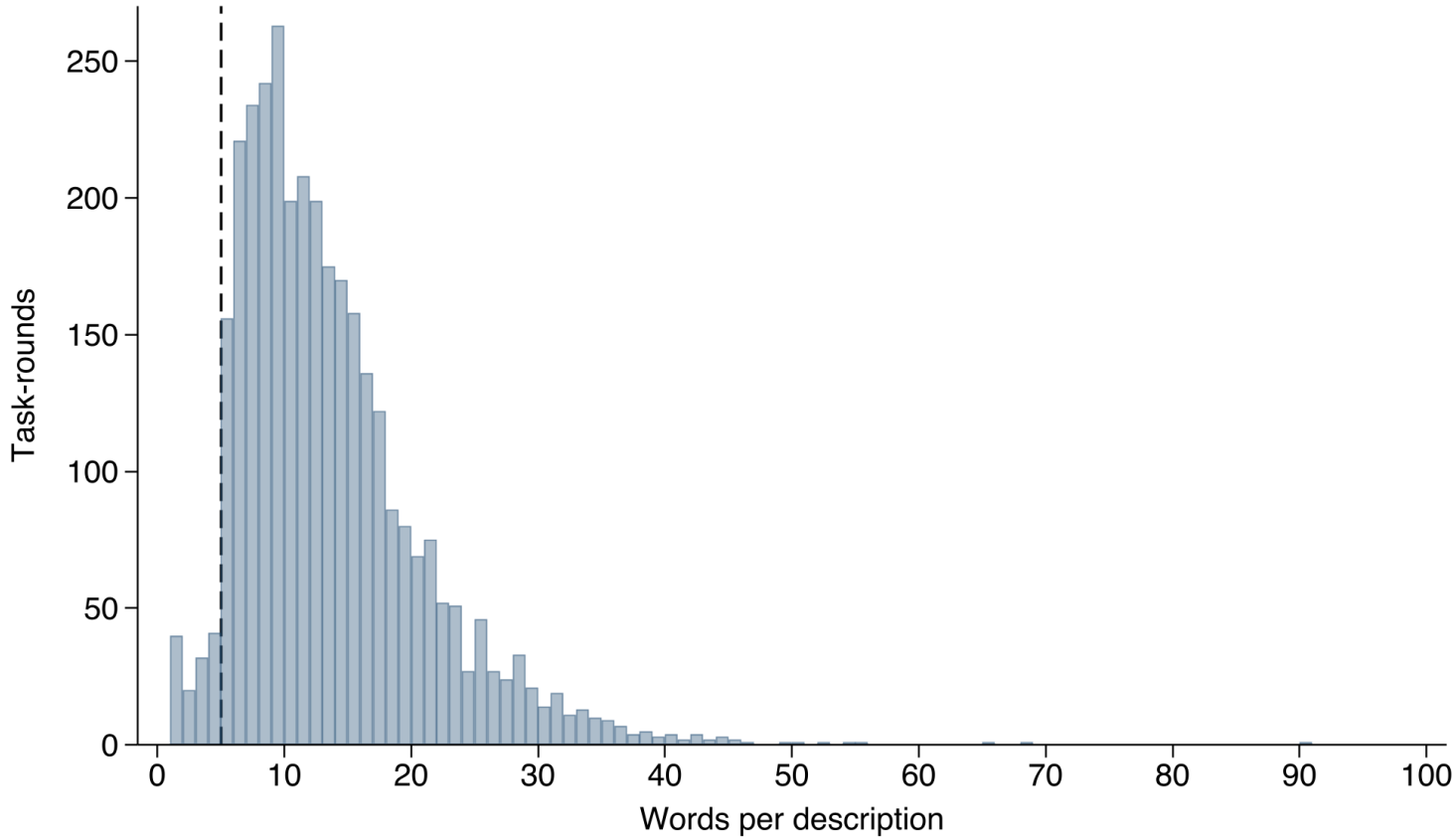
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5. Exploratory: no detectable heterogeneity in the meaning-output relationship by incentive type

Summary statistics

	N	Mean	SD	Min	Max
Age	832	41.073	14.599	18	83
Female	832	0.552	0.498	0	1
White	832	0.651	0.477	0	1
Asian	832	0.046	0.209	0	1
Black	832	0.202	0.402	0	1
US-born	832	0.923	0.267	0	1
Student	832	0.141	0.348	0	1
Full-time employed	832	0.374	0.484	0	1
Part-time employed	832	0.233	0.423	0	1
No college degree	832	0.227	0.419	0	1
Baseline mood	832	4.073	0.770	1	5
Demographics first	832	0.506	0.500	0	1

Analytic sample of 832 workers recruited on Prolific in four waves in 2025, from Prolific profile data and in-survey questions. Baseline mood on a 1–5 scale. Indicators for being Asian, US-born, or a student are not used as controls because they vary little in the sample. 25 workers in waves 1–2 who skipped a choice round are excluded.

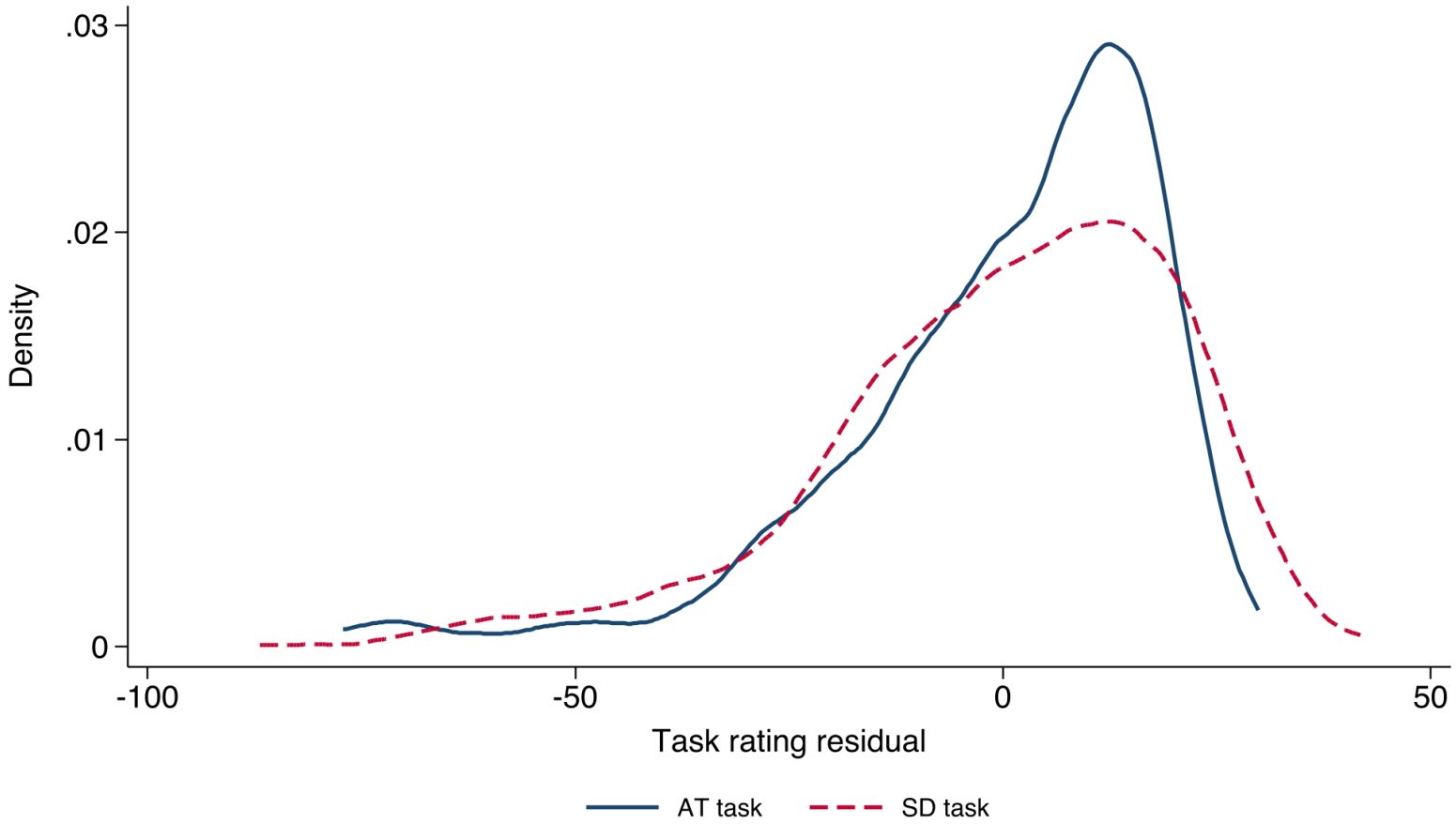
Average wordcount is above the 5-word minimum



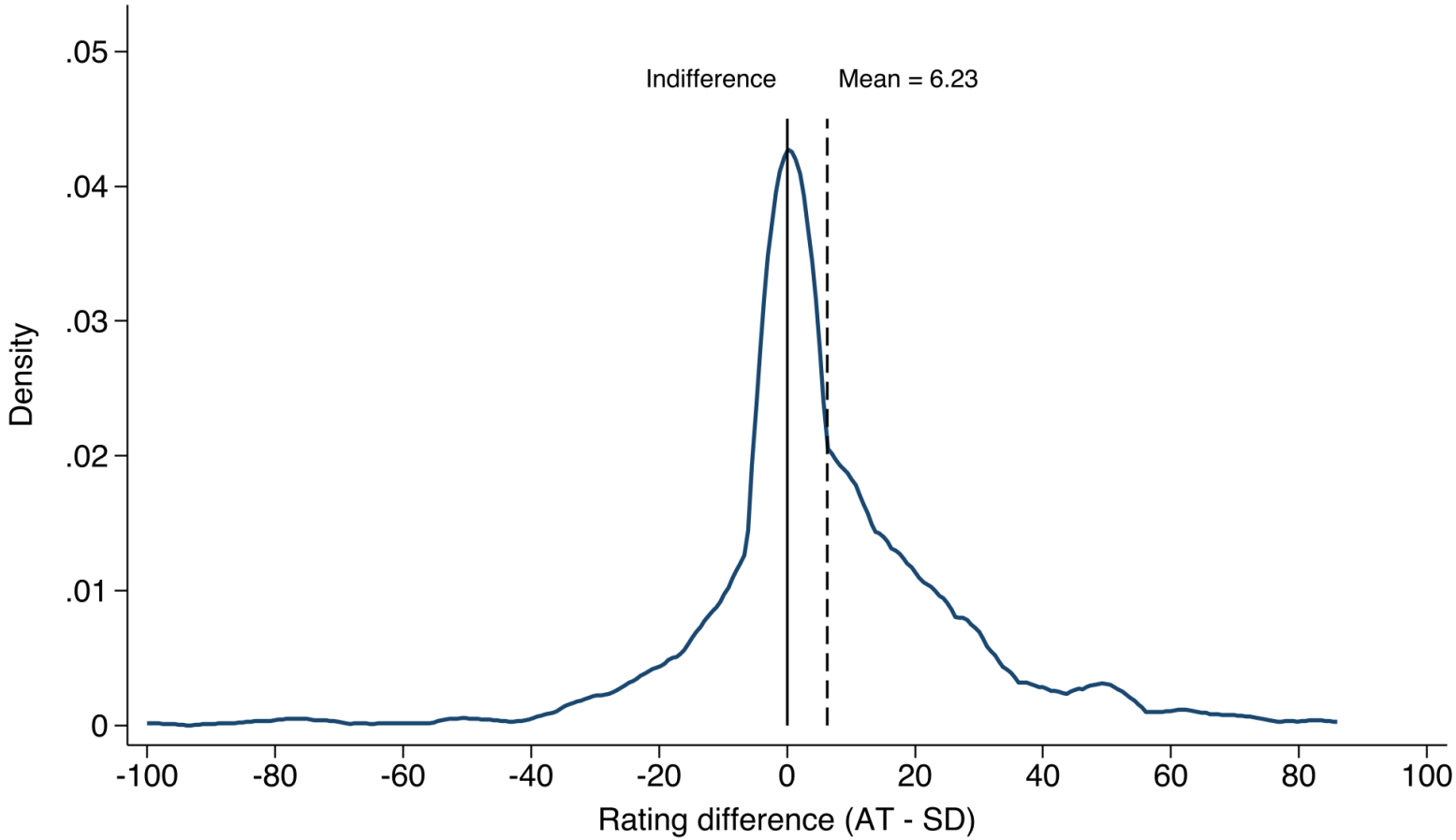
Mean 13.15 words; only 4.0% of assigned task-rounds fall below the minimum

ECDFs Time and quality

Densities of meaningfulness ratings, residualized



AT task more meaningful on average, but not for all



Mean AT−SD gap of 6.23 points ($p < 0.001$), yet 26.1% rate SD higher and 20.9% rate them equally little learning-by-doing correlations

Estimating meaning and output

In the randomly assigned rounds 5–8, separately for AT and SD rounds:

$$y_{irt} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 w_{ir} + \boldsymbol{\beta_2 m_{it}} + \beta_3 d_{it} + \gamma_r + \alpha_{a(i)} + \delta_{w(i)} + \boldsymbol{\Gamma}' \boldsymbol{X}_i + \varepsilon_{irt}$$

- **Own meaning rating of the assigned task $\boldsymbol{m_{it}}$** (before working)
- Endline difficulty $d_{it} \approx C_i(e_{it})$; round, arm, and wave FEs; questionnaire order and demographics in $\boldsymbol{X}_i$
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- Average-task design: replace m_{it} with an indicator for assignment to AT
- m_{it} does not vary within worker and task, so β_2 compares workers: a conditional association, not a within-worker effect

Average-task assignment vs. worker-level meaning

	Wordcount	Quality	Time
A. Random assignment to the AT task, all rounds			
AT round	-0.891	1.548	-2.261
	(0.272)	(0.737)	(0.607)
	$[p = 0.001]$	$[p = 0.036]$	$[p = 0.000]$
B. Worker-level meaning, AT rounds			
Own rating	0.032	0.087	0.096
	(0.012)	(0.039)	(0.028)
	$[p = 0.009]$	$[p = 0.026]$	$[p = 0.001]$
C. Worker-level meaning, SD rounds			
Own rating	-0.028	-0.038	0.022
	(0.015)	(0.032)	(0.029)
	$[p = 0.062]$	$[p = 0.231]$	$[p = 0.448]$

OLS with demographic controls; round pay, own difficulty, round, arm, and wave FEs. SEs clustered by subject. 832 workers, 3328 task-rounds.

full table

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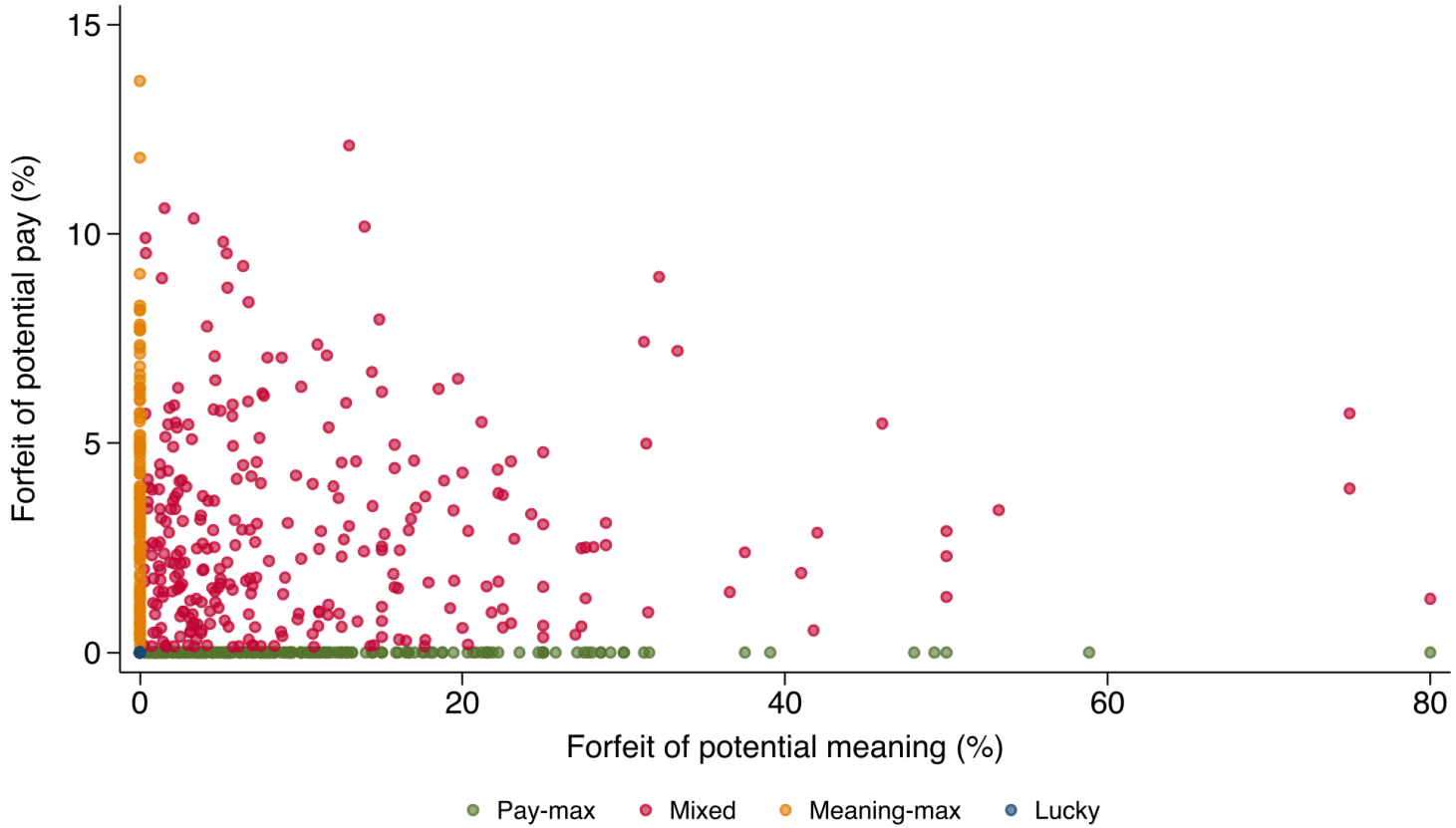
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$\Rightarrow$ The average-task design assigns "meaningful work" to some workers who perceive it as the *less* meaningful task

Preference for work meaning is worker idiosyncratic



Pay and meaning forgone over the four choice rounds, 658 strict rankers

Worker types by work choice behavior

Observed Choice(s)	Incentive Type	Values of ϕ	Share
Meaning left on table	*Pay-maximizer*	$\phi = 1$	35.4%
Meaning & pay left on table	*Mixed incentive-type*	$\phi \in (0, 1)$	43.9%
Pay left on table	*Meaning-maximizer*	$\phi = 0$	17.2%
Nothing left on table	*Lucky*	*Not characterized*	3.5%

Note: Strict rankers ($n = 658$); the 20.9% of workers who rate the two tasks equally cannot give up meaning in any choice and are not classified alternative handling.

- **H1 validated:** types identified from choices with a known outside option, and heterogeneous; choice dynamics stable by round
- Workers who value meaning forgo 3.1% of available pay on average $\approx$ 3.6% of Maestas et al. 2023 for community impact
- 48.3% of all workers give up pay for meaning in at least one choice; cf. around 40% in De Schouwer et al. 2025 (hypothetical choice)

Pay share of forgone incentives, mixed types

Caveats on the incentive types

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- Shares are similar in the no-intervention arms (37.8%, 15.8%, 41.1%, 5.4%)

Perceptions do not (cleanly) reveal preferences

	AT task		SD task	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Meaning-maximizer	0.15	0.57	-5.95**	-6.11**
	(2.03)	(2.07)	(2.35)	(2.37)
Mixed incentive-type	-2.71*	-2.28	-0.41	-0.61
	(1.59)	(1.63)	(1.70)	(1.72)
Observations	658	635	658	635
Omitted-group mean	80.75	80.45	72.57	72.87
Lucky workers dropped		✓		✓

Before-working ratings (0–100) on type indicators, strict rankers; omitted group pay-maximizers (and lucky in columns 1 and 3). Demographic controls, questionnaire order, arm and wave FEs; robust SEs.

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- Pay-maximizers and mixed types rate both tasks indistinguishably
- Meaning-maximizers rate AT no higher than pay-maximizers, and SD lower: distinguished by a larger *gap*, not higher ratings

Figure Preferences largely independent of observables

Output and meaning by incentive type (exploratory)

	AT rounds			SD rounds		
	Wordcount	Quality	Time	Wordcount	Quality	Time
A. Workers who value meaning ($n = 402$)						
Own rating of assigned task	0.039**	0.085	0.097**	-0.046*	-0.075	0.009
	(0.017)	(0.055)	(0.039)	(0.024)	(0.050)	(0.043)
Task-rounds	808	807	808	800	797	800
B. Pay-maximizers ($n = 233$)						
Own rating of assigned task	0.048*	0.132	0.101	0.012	-0.114	-0.029
	(0.025)	(0.082)	(0.070)	(0.024)	(0.091)	(0.056)
Task-rounds	494	493	494	438	436	438
Equality of slopes, p	0.951	0.970	0.947	0.176	0.744	0.546

Coefficient on own rating of the assigned task; OLS with demographic controls, as in the main specification. SEs clustered by subject.

Coefficient plot

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- One reading: ϕ captures the weight on meaning at the margin of task *choice*, not at the margin of *effort*, where meaning carries no monetary cost in this design

Robustness

- **Alternative estimators** (PPML, fractional logit, Tobit): worker-level AT estimates 0.032, 0.086, 0.107 vs. OLS 0.032, 0.087, 0.096 summary

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- **Power**: minimum detectable AT slopes 0.034, 0.110, 0.079, close to the estimates

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- Preferences may matter more for the *choice* of work than for effort on work once chosen

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- In the lab and the field, elicit both perceptions of and preferences for meaning

Thank you!

My other works in progress:

What Moves Meaning? Investigating Drivers of an Idiosyncratic Incentive

Benefits on the Bench: Workfare, Mental Health, and the Role of the Team
with Carlos Brito (UC Davis)

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Experimental design: task training (randomized order)

Good alternative text descriptions should put the most essential information about an image first while not being too wordy.



Here are some examples of good alt text descriptions for this image:

(1) Person using a laptop with external drives and SD cards on a wooden desk.

(2) Laptop connected to an external SSD, with SD cards and portable drives nearby.

(3) Close-up of hands typing on a laptop next to storage devices.

(4) Wooden table with a laptop, SD cards, and Samsung portable SSDs.

(5) Laptop setup with external storage devices used for data transfer.

Good subjective descriptions should highlight key features of an image while also incorporating the subject's own perspective.



Here are some examples of good subjective descriptions for this image:

(1) Cherry wood table, fresh tulips, and books suggest a space loved and lived in.

(2) Formal dining room with bookshelf, portraits, and mirrored sideboard invites artful conversation.

(3) Glossy chairs, pendant light, and vivid flowers animate this refined, well-curated gathering space.

(4) Ornate frames, warm wood, and a bookshelf create a nostalgic yet intentional dining nook.

(5) Whimsical figurines, a child's portrait, and soft lighting evoke curiosity amid classic decor.

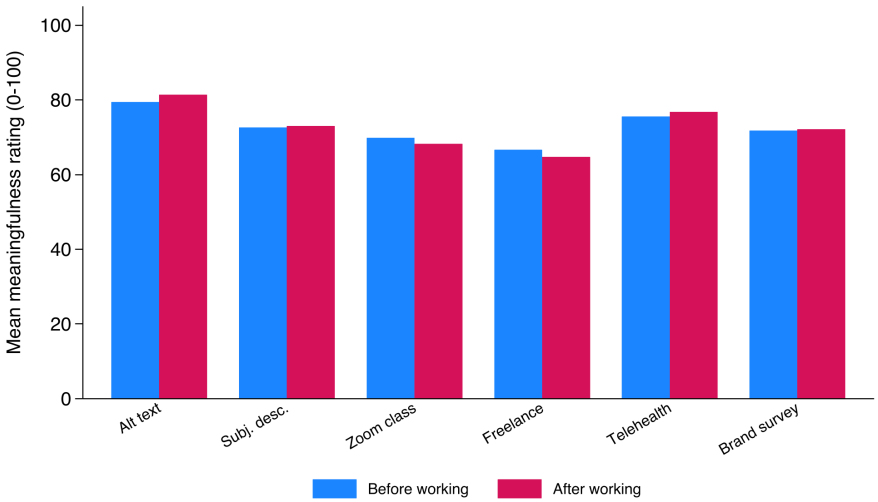
Experimental design: attention check

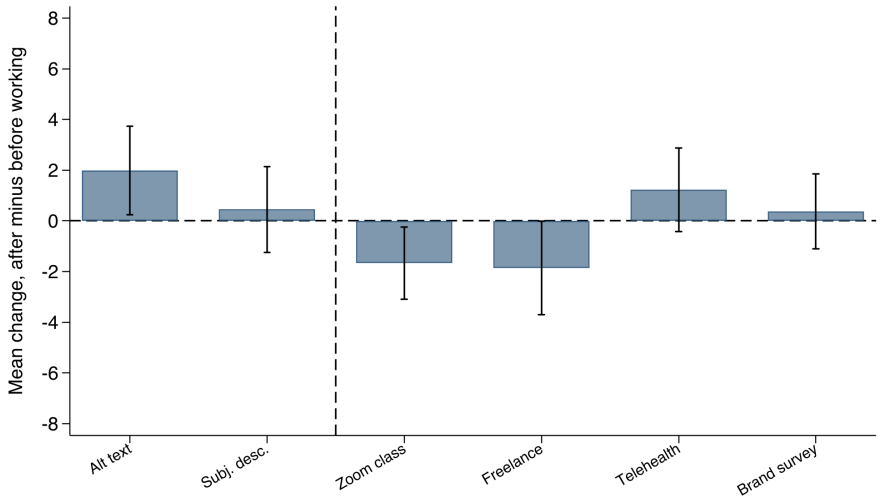
Please indicate your understanding of this experiment by selecting all tasks you will be asked to complete.

- ☐ Poetry-writing task
- ☐ Puzzle solving task
- ☐ Python coding task
- ☐ Alternative text task
- ☐ Subjective description task

(Randomized order; placebo arm in waves 1–2, all workers in waves 3–4) Back

Task meaningfulness ratings before and after working





No-intervention arms; left: mean ratings, right: change after minus before working

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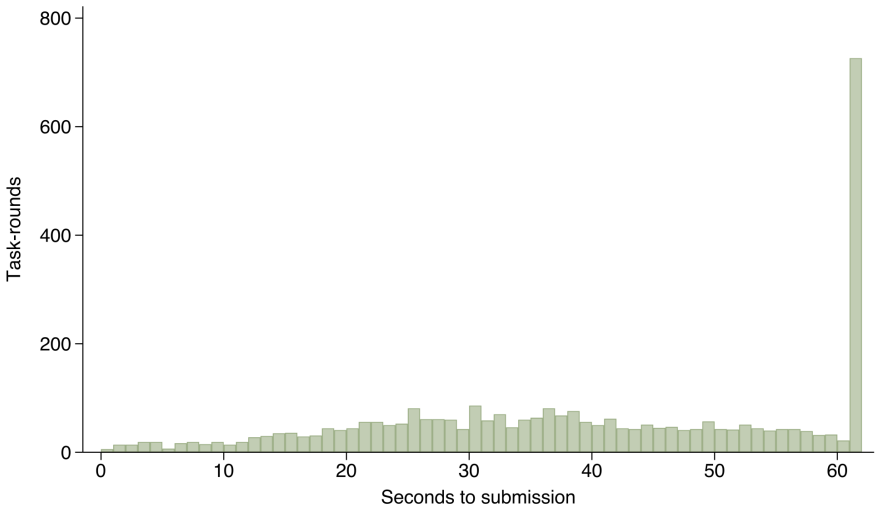
Correlations of before-working task ratings

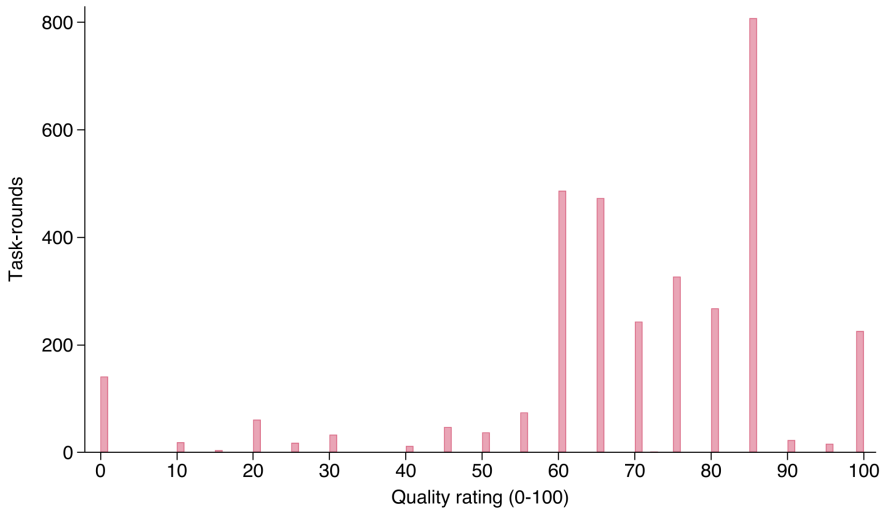
	AT	SD	Zoom class	Freelance	Telehealth	Brand survey
AT	1.00					
SD	0.51	1.00				
Zoom class	0.41	0.37	1.00			
Freelance	0.36	0.50	0.51	1.00		
Telehealth	0.48	0.26	0.60	0.37	1.00	
Brand survey	0.31	0.69	0.18	0.41	0.08	1.00

Decoys: teaching a class over Zoom, digital freelance work, virtual telehealth, and brand surveys on Prolific.

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Distributions of submission time and quality

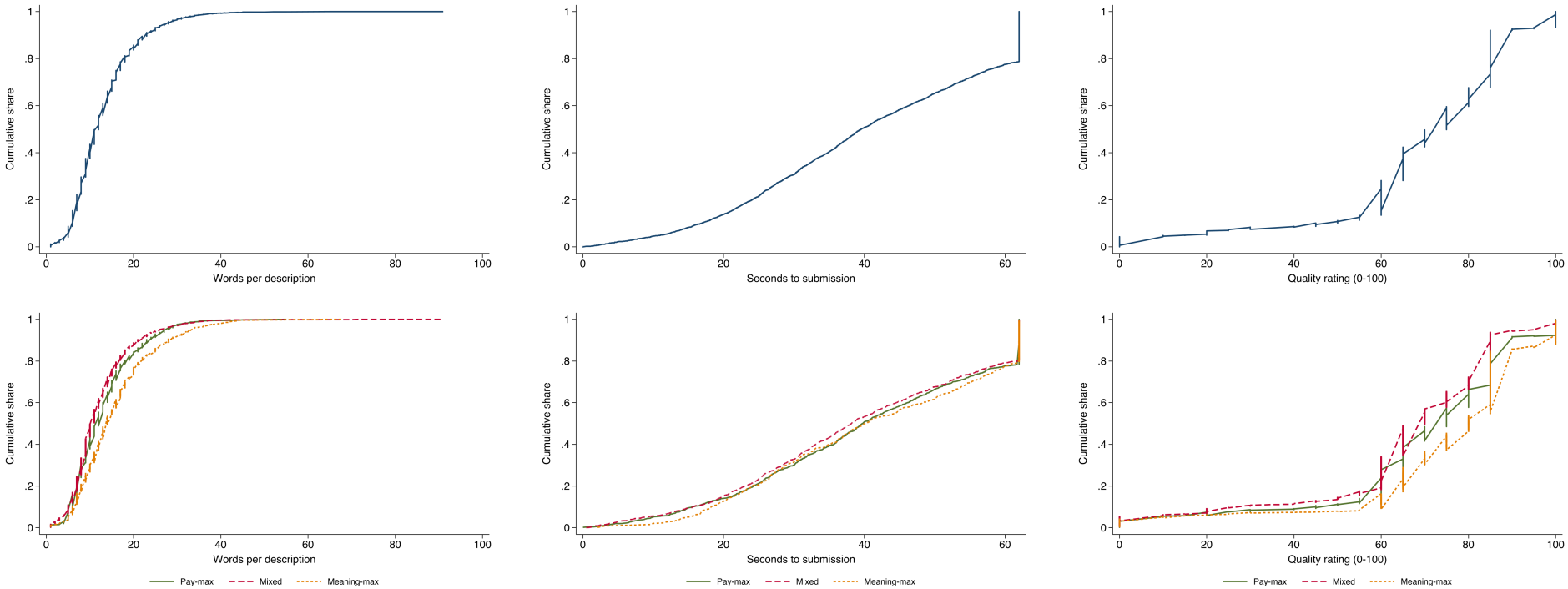




Mean 40.14 seconds (rounds submit automatically after 62); mean quality $69.11/100$

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Empirical CDFs of output



Top: all task-rounds; bottom: by incentive type (strict rankers)

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Average-task assignment vs. worker-level meaning: full

	Wordcount		Quality		Time	
Panel A. Random assignment to the AT task, all rounds						
Round pay (cents)	0.004	0.003	0.014	0.011	-0.002	-0.002
	(0.005)	(0.005)	(0.012)	(0.012)	(0.010)	(0.010)
AT round	-0.931***	-0.891***	1.427*	1.548**	-2.317***	-2.261***
	(0.274)	(0.272)	(0.753)	(0.737)	(0.609)	(0.607)
Own difficulty of assigned task	0.003	-0.000	-0.044**	-0.054**	0.100***	0.093***
	(0.008)	(0.007)	(0.022)	(0.021)	(0.017)	(0.017)
Task-rounds	3328	3328	3318	3318	3328	3328
DV mean	13.15	13.15	69.11	69.11	40.14	40.14
Panel B. Worker-level meaningfulness, AT rounds						
Round pay (cents)	0.005	0.004	0.002	-0.001	0.014	0.015
	(0.006)	(0.006)	(0.016)	(0.015)	(0.014)	(0.014)
Own rating of assigned task	0.029**	0.032***	0.077**	0.087**	0.099***	0.096***
	(0.012)	(0.012)	(0.036)	(0.039)	(0.027)	(0.028)
Own difficulty of assigned task	-0.011	-0.013	-0.098***	-0.103***	0.077***	0.071***
	(0.009)	(0.008)	(0.028)	(0.028)	(0.021)	(0.021)
Task-rounds	1686	1686	1682	1682	1686	1686
DV mean	12.65	12.65	70.07	70.07	38.64	38.64
Panel C. Worker-level meaningfulness, SD rounds						
Round pay (cents)	0.001	-0.001	0.021	0.018	-0.021	-0.022
	(0.007)	(0.007)	(0.018)	(0.018)	(0.014)	(0.014)
Own rating of assigned task	-0.043***	-0.028*	-0.078**	-0.038	0.012	0.022
	(0.015)	(0.015)	(0.032)	(0.032)	(0.028)	(0.029)
Own difficulty of assigned task	0.016*	0.012	0.011	-0.004	0.119***	0.113***
	(0.009)	(0.009)	(0.026)	(0.025)	(0.020)	(0.020)
Task-rounds	1642	1642	1636	1636	1642	1642
DV mean	13.65	13.65	68.13	68.13	41.67	41.67
Demographics		✓		✓		✓

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Worker-level meaning and output, both tasks pooled

	Wordcount		Quality		Time	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Round pay (cents)	0.004	0.003	0.014	0.010	-0.002	-0.002
	(0.005)	(0.005)	(0.012)	(0.012)	(0.010)	(0.010)
Own rating of assigned task	-0.011	0.000	-0.011	0.017	0.051**	0.057**
	(0.011)	(0.010)	(0.026)	(0.027)	(0.022)	(0.023)
AT round	-0.858***	-0.892***	1.501*	1.434*	-2.670***	-2.652***
	(0.273)	(0.271)	(0.794)	(0.778)	(0.617)	(0.618)
Own difficulty of assigned task	0.003	-0.000	-0.044**	-0.054**	0.099***	0.092***
	(0.008)	(0.007)	(0.022)	(0.021)	(0.017)	(0.017)
Task-rounds	3328	3328	3318	3318	3328	3328
DV mean	13.15	13.15	69.11	69.11	40.14	40.14
Demographics		✓		✓		✓

OLS; round, arm, and wave FEs and questionnaire order. SEs clustered by subject.

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Robustness of the worker-level meaning coefficients

	AT rounds			SD rounds		
	Wordcount	Quality	Time	Wordcount	Quality	Time
Panel A. Outcomes in levels (words, rating points, seconds)						
OLS (main specification)	0.032***	0.087**	0.096***	-0.028*	-0.038	0.022
	(0.012)	(0.039)	(0.028)	(0.015)	(0.032)	(0.029)
Wild cluster bootstrap p	[0.012]	[0.027]	[0.002]	[0.070]	[0.262]	[0.449]
PPML / fractional logit / Tobit	0.032***	0.086**	0.107***	-0.026*	-0.040	0.025
	(0.012)	(0.038)	(0.033)	(0.014)	(0.033)	(0.037)
Waves 3–4 only	0.039***	0.099**	0.067*	-0.031	-0.026	-0.021
	(0.013)	(0.045)	(0.035)	(0.020)	(0.039)	(0.037)
No-intervention arms only	0.020	0.084	0.097**	-0.016	0.014	-0.015
	(0.016)	(0.062)	(0.041)	(0.023)	(0.042)	(0.041)
Time as an input	0.027**	0.083**		-0.030**	-0.041	
	(0.012)	(0.039)		(0.015)	(0.032)	
Excluding the INFO arm	0.039***	0.129***	0.096***	-0.027*	-0.022	0.016
	(0.013)	(0.043)	(0.030)	(0.016)	(0.034)	(0.031)
Without own difficulty	0.031**	0.081**	0.100***	-0.027*	-0.038	0.024
	(0.012)	(0.039)	(0.029)	(0.015)	(0.032)	(0.029)
Panel B. Quality standardized within wave, $(q - \bar{q}_w)/\sigma_w$						
Standardized quality, $\times 100$		0.394**			-0.185	
		(0.187)			(0.154)	

Coefficient on own rating of the assigned task. Panel B: hundredths of a within-wave standard deviation σ_w of quality per rating point.

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Own meaning and output: between and within workers

	Wordcount	Quality	Time
AT task			
Between workers	0.032***	0.087**	0.096***
	(0.012)	(0.039)	(0.028)
Within worker	-0.000	-0.007	-0.013
	(0.014)	(0.034)	(0.034)
Within worker, difficulty control	0.001	-0.015	-0.003
	(0.014)	(0.034)	(0.035)
SD task			
Between workers	-0.028*	-0.038	0.022
	(0.015)	(0.032)	(0.029)
Within worker	-0.013	-0.006	-0.043
	(0.013)	(0.032)	(0.029)
Within worker, difficulty control	-0.011	-0.018	-0.028
	(0.013)	(0.033)	(0.029)

Within-worker slopes from the 730 workers assigned both tasks.

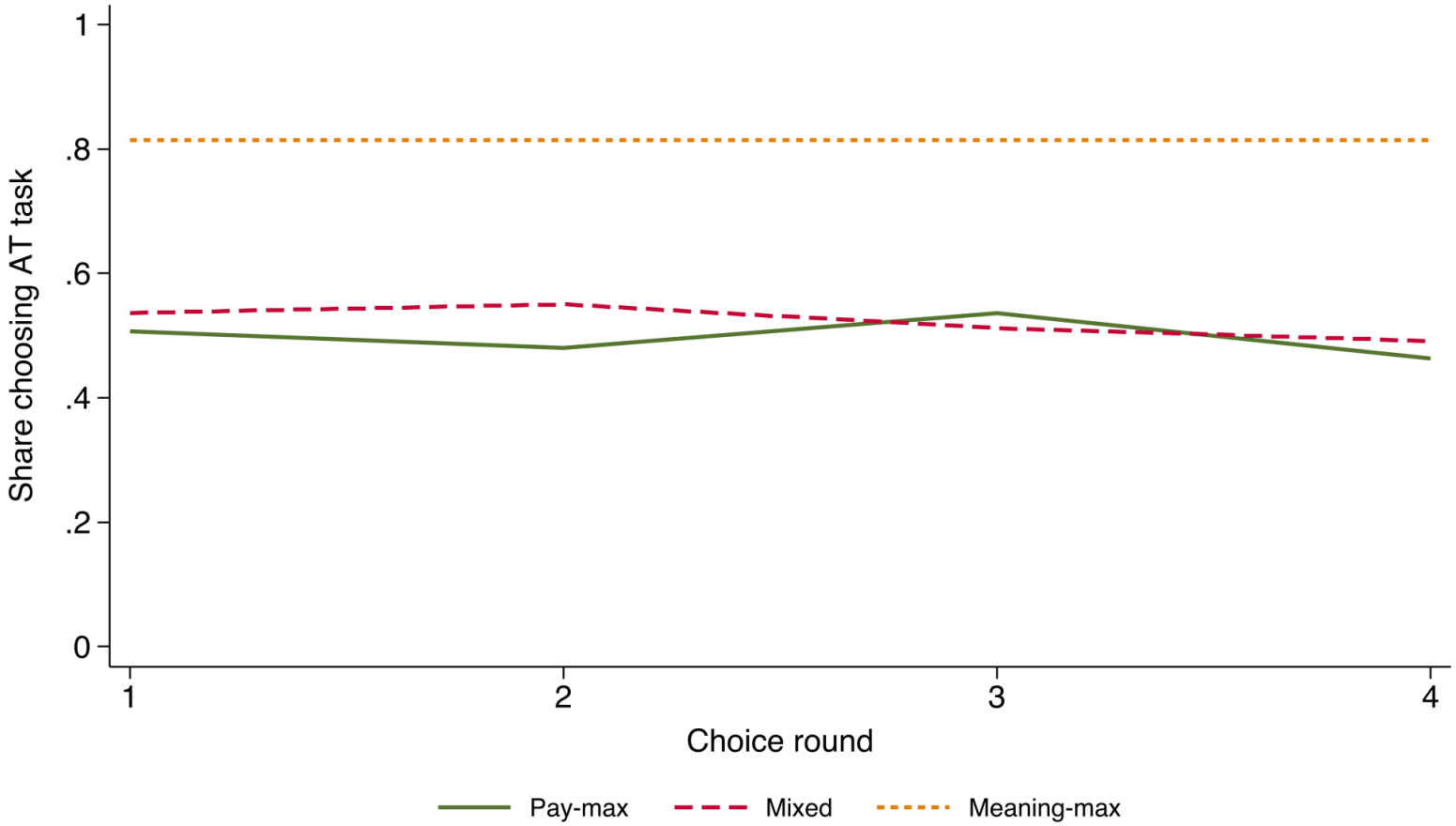
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Incentive-type shares under alternative handling

	Strict rankers (main)	All workers, original classification	All workers, five categories
Pay-maximizer	35.4	28.2	28.0
Meaning-maximizer	17.2	26.9	13.6
Mixed incentive-type	43.9	35.0	34.7
Lucky	3.5	9.9	2.8
Indifferent (tied raters)			20.9
Workers	658	832	832

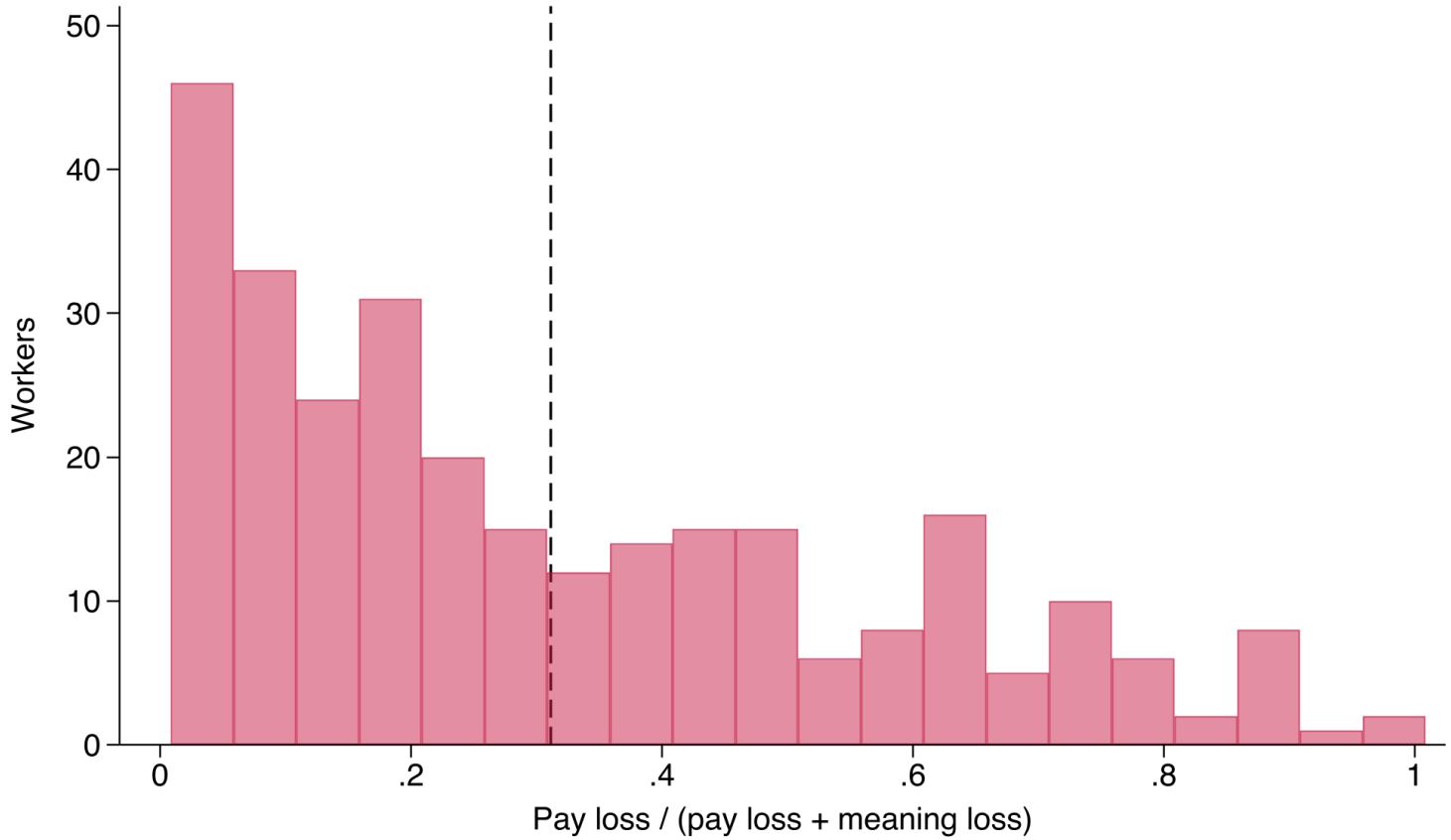
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Share choosing the AT task by round and incentive type



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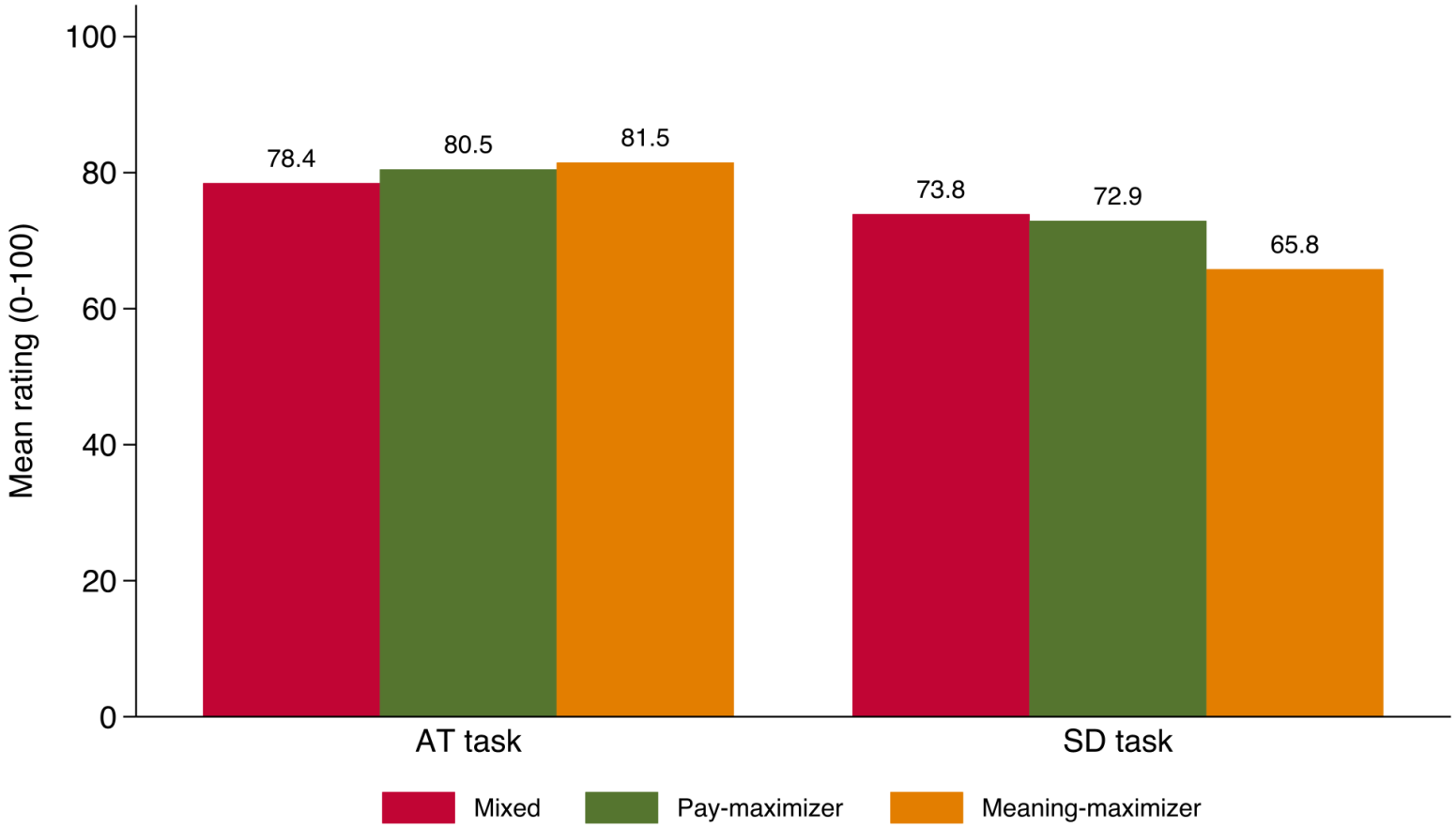
Pay share of forgone incentives, mixed incentive-types



payloss/(payloss + meaningloss): 0 for a worker who gives up only meaning, 1 for one who gives up only pay

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Mean before-working task ratings by incentive type



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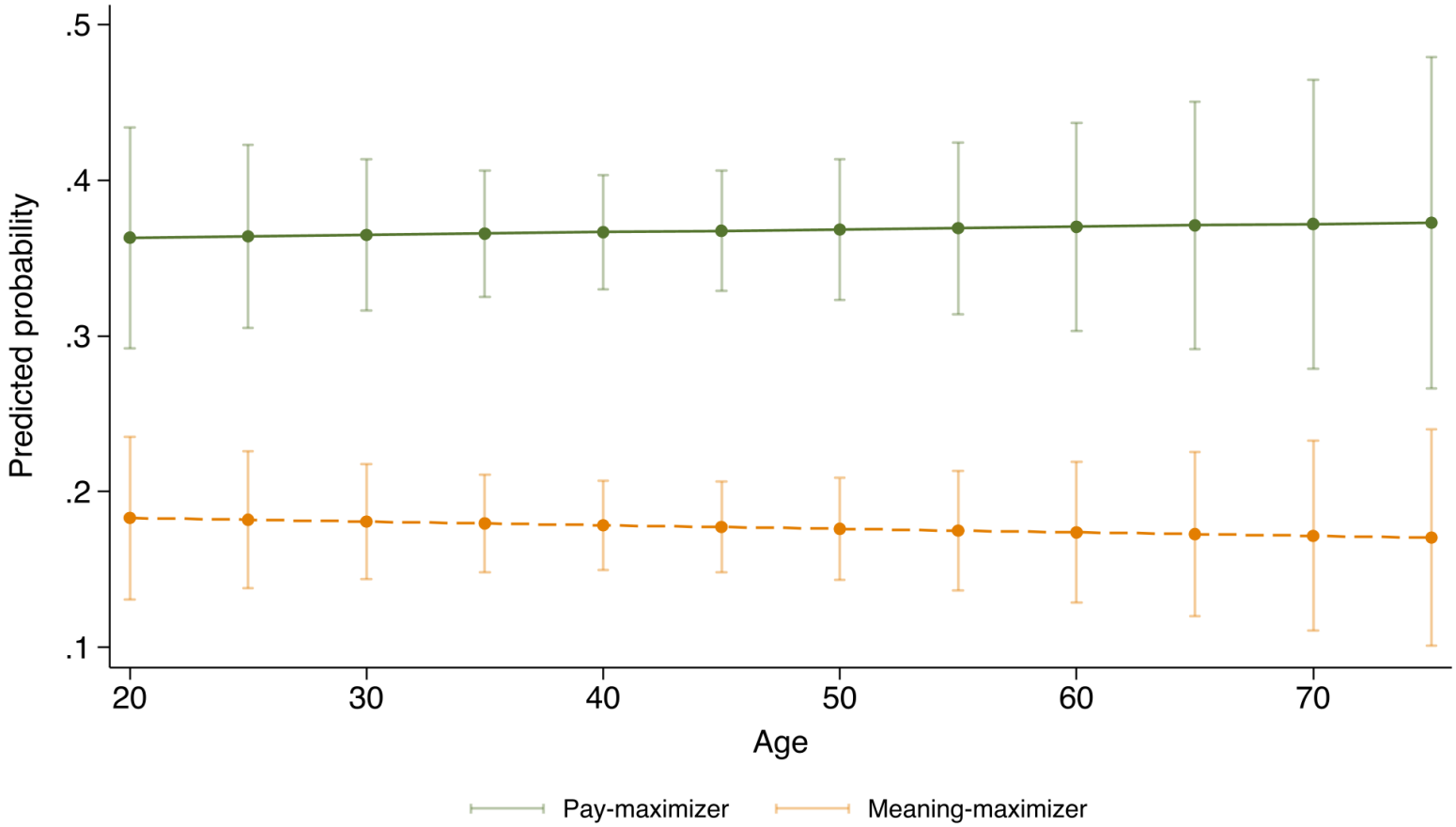
Mlogit of incentive type on ratings and observables

	Pay-max vs mixed	Meaning-max vs mixed
AT task rating	0.007	0.018**
	(0.005)	(0.008)
SD task rating	-0.001	-0.020***
	(0.005)	(0.007)
Age	0.000	-0.002
	(0.007)	(0.008)
Female	0.299	-0.042
	(0.189)	(0.240)
White	-0.104	-0.113
	(0.291)	(0.320)
Black	-0.490	-0.272
	(0.348)	(0.430)
Full-time employed	-0.066	-0.305
	(0.215)	(0.263)
Part-time employed	-0.010	-0.383
	(0.262)	(0.322)
No college degree	-0.170	-0.034
	(0.236)	(0.282)
Baseline mood	-0.062	-0.347**
	(0.136)	(0.146)
Observations	635	

Strict rankers, lucky workers excluded; base outcome mixed incentive-types. Ratings and demographic controls.

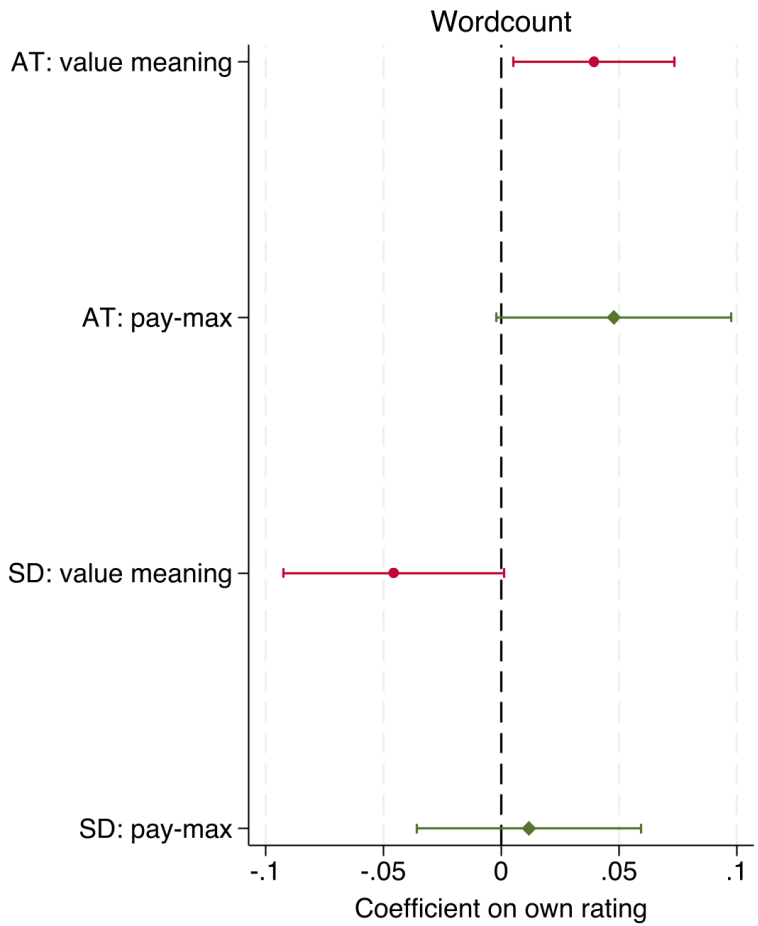
Back By age

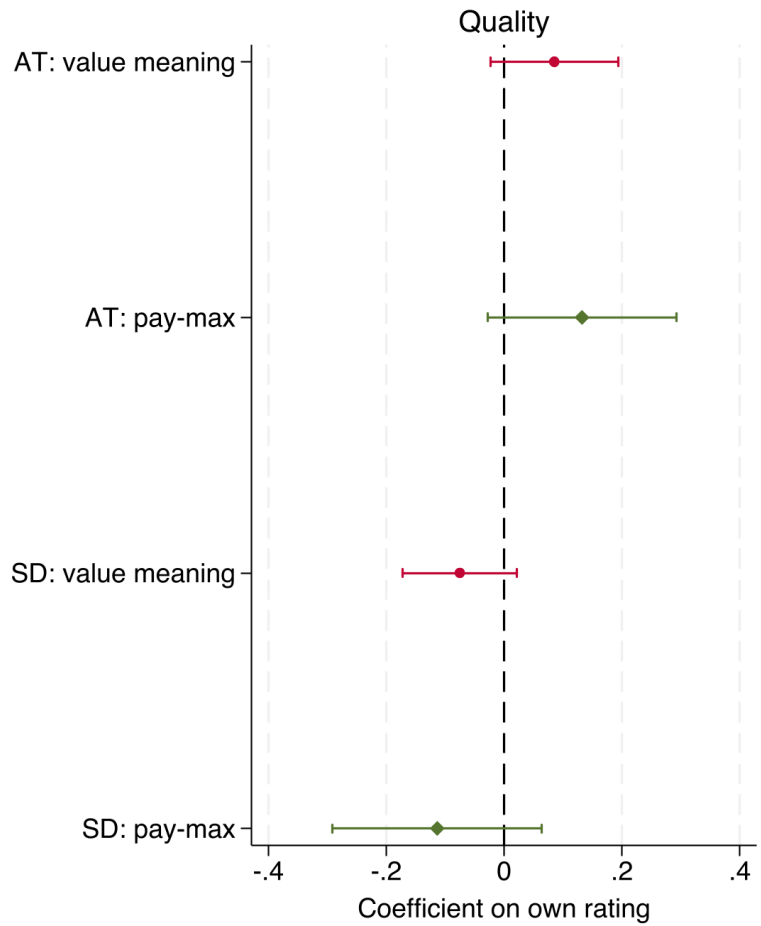
Predicted probability of incentive type by age



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Coefficient on own rating by task and incentive type





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Satisfaction and the summed meaning of assigned work

Across workers

	(1) All	(2) Value meaning	(3) Pay-max
Summed own rating of assigned tasks	0.087***	0.076***	0.096***
	(0.010)	(0.015)	(0.021)
Summed own difficulty of assigned tasks	-0.059***	-0.069***	-0.042***
	(0.007)	(0.011)	(0.013)
Summed pay of assigned rounds (cents)	0.010	0.011	-0.016
	(0.012)	(0.018)	(0.023)
Observations	832	402	233
DV mean	73.39	70.26	73.45
Demographics	✓	✓	✓

Own ratings of both tasks held fixed

	(1) All	(2) Value meaning	(3) Pay-max
Summed own rating of assigned tasks	-0.047	-0.059	0.035
	(0.032)	(0.037)	(0.074)
Summed own difficulty of assigned tasks	-0.094**	-0.165***	0.053
	(0.040)	(0.048)	(0.072)
Summed pay of assigned rounds (cents)	0.010	0.011	-0.011
	(0.012)	(0.018)	(0.023)
Observations	832	402	233
DV mean	73.39	70.26	73.45
Own ratings of both tasks	✓	✓	✓
Demographics	✓	✓	✓

Satisfaction with responses in rounds 5–8 (0–100), unincentivized; robust SEs.

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What Moves Meaning? - Beauregard

Title: What Moves Meaning? Investigating Drivers of an Idiosyncratic Incentive

Abstract: I develop an online experiment with 832 participants on Prolific to examine how five light-touch interventions, drawing on two distinct approaches, affect the subjective experience of work. These include information emphasizing the social importance of a task and prompts asking workers to generate their own reasons for a task's importance or to reflect on what they personally find meaningful. No intervention detectably moves the average perceived meaningfulness of either task, perceived difficulty, satisfaction, mood, or the incentives workers reveal in paid choices. In exploratory analyses by incentive type, I find positive estimates for meaning concentrated among workers whose paid choices reveal that they value work meaning. Together, these findings suggest that perceived work meaning is difficult to move with brief prompts, but that any gains are likely to be concentrated among workers who already value meaning.

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Benefits on the Bench - Beauregard & Brito

Title: Benefits on the Bench: Workfare, Mental Health, and the Role of the Team

Abstract: Recent studies have found large positive effects of working compared to pure cash transfers on various measures of mental health for labor demand-constrained populations. We hypothesize that some such benefits could stem from belonging to and training with a team even if one is not ultimately selected to work, which we term as "being on the bench". This study proposes a novel field experiment to investigate the effects of being placed on the bench by a randomized employment lottery for forcibly displaced Venezuelan migrants in Roraima, a Brazilian border state. This population is understood to have both high unemployment and job-seeking as well as poor mental health, making them both appropriate and necessary to study. As we expect these effects to operate through alignment with the meaningfulness or mission of work being trained for, we introduce variation in the meaningfulness of tasks offered. Similar to previous studies, we also include a cash transfer treatment arm and pure control for comparison.

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Preregistration (AEARCTR-0015326) and deviations

	Preregistered (Feb. 2025)	Implemented
Sample	2,000 workers	832 workers in four waves
Arms	Eight: rating timing × mission information × training round	Features given to all; no-intervention arm and five prompts, not registered, entered only as controls
Rounds	Five	Eight (four choice, four assigned)
Task choice	Probability of selecting a task	Pay and meaning forgone ⇒ incentive types (strict rankers)
Effort	Wordcount; AI quality; words per second; 5-word threshold	Wordcount, quality as registered; submission time; threshold not analyzed (4.0% of rounds below)
Secondary	Mood; probability of working vs. skipping	Baseline mood a control; skipping (waves 1–2) defines the sample
Hypotheses	None registered	H1–H2 and all specifications developed after registration ⇒ by-type analysis exploratory

Minimum detectable AT slopes (80% power, 5%): 0.034 words, 0.110 quality, 0.079 seconds; no formal multiple-comparison correction

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